

THROUGH THE AGES

Witchcraft

Although the idea of the witch is as old as humanity, it was first linked to gender during Europe's 15th-century Inquisition. Witch-hunting hysteria had peaked by the 17th century, and thousands of women had been unfairly persecuted and violently killed.

▼ The Hammer of Witches

Witches were prosecuted based on treatises like the *Malleus Maleficarum* of 1486, which prescribed torture and encouraged execution. Such guides depicted witches as wanton women who consorted with demons.



A VERSION OF WITCHCRAFT appears in most human cultures, and has usually been viewed with fear and suspicion. Accusations of its practice have mostly focused on women, particularly the aged and the poor. When medicine became the preserve of men, the “wise women” who administered traditional remedies to the poor were also targeted.

The powers ascribed to witches have varied over time and place. They were often thought to be able to fly and command demons, but other abilities assigned to them included using animals (called “familiars”) to spy on and attack people, or turning into animals themselves. Witches were also thought to cause illness, impotence, and infertility, as well as make livestock fall sick or stop producing.

Persecutions

Between the mid-15th century and the end of the 18th century, by which time popular and learned opinion had become skeptical of the existence of witchcraft and witch hunts were nearly extinct, there were around 100,000 trials and 50,000 executions for witchcraft in Europe. About 80 percent of the victims were women, and about half of the persecutions took place in German-speaking lands. Europe during this era was beset by near-constant warfare, religious

“
You’re a liar!
I am no more [a]
witch than you
are a wizard.”

SARAH GOOD, ONE OF THE FIRST VICTIMS OF THE SALEM TRIALS, 1692

controversy, and economic uncertainty. Such troubles contributed to an atmosphere in which people looked for a scapegoat for social ills, and trials notably peaked at times of recession. One case often created a chain-reaction of accusation—such as in Sweden from 1668–1676, where sorcery claims against a woman called Märet Jonsdotter spiraled into hysteria and resulted in around 280 executions. Overzealous officials led mass persecutions, too—as in England from 1644 to 1647, when Matthew Hopkins, the self-appointed “Witchfinder General,” executed 300 women.

Paranoia about witches spread to the United States, helped by English Puritans who settled in New England. Such suspicion resulted in the Salem witch trials of 1692–1693, which began after a group of young girls, who had been telling fortunes, started to show signs of demonic possession and accused three women of bewitching them. The trials led to the execution of 14 women and five men.